



P25 · 16 PAGES, SCRIPTS + WORKSHEETS

A Holiday Boundary Pack

Sixteen pages for the holiday gatherings where the comments come fast, the questions come faster, and you are also trying to keep a small human fed. Script library for the most common moments. A pre-gathering worksheet. A grounding card library for the bathroom break. A debrief page for the drive home.

Soothemade Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

The holidays are when every previously-deferred conversation lands at the same table at the same time. The body comment. The pregnancy question. The unsolicited parenting advice. The “back in my day.” The political comment, three times before dessert.

You can do hard. You have been doing hard. The thing that makes the holiday gathering uniquely depleting is not any single comment. It is the sustained low-level effort of holding yourself together for hours, while also trying to keep a small human fed and a partnership intact, while also being the person who is “doing well, thank you for asking.”

This pack is for that. The scripts so you don’t have to invent them in the moment. The grounding cards so you have somewhere to go. The debrief page so the drive home doesn’t become another loop.

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The pre-gathering worksheet

Fill this in 2-3 days before the gathering. It buys you about 70% of the calmness you'll have during.

DATE OF GATHERING: _____

WHO WILL BE THERE

- ☐ _____ (relationship: _____)
- ☐ _____ (relationship: _____)
- ☐ _____ (relationship: _____)
- ☐ _____ (relationship: _____)
- ☐ _____ (relationship: _____)
- ☐ _____ (relationship: _____)

THE PEOPLE I'M MOST WORRIED ABOUT

1. _____ Why: _____
2. _____ Why: _____

THE THREE COMMENTS LIKELY TO COME UP

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

THE TWO THINGS I WILL NOT ENGAGE ON, NO MATTER WHAT

1. _____
2. _____

THE ONE THING I AM WILLING TO DISCUSS, IF ASKED KINDLY

WHAT I WANT FOR MYSELF FROM THIS GATHERING

- ☐ To leave feeling I held my own
- ☐ To leave by ____:____ pm
- ☐ To eat one full meal sitting down
- ☐ To not cry in the bathroom
- ☐ To not lose my temper at my partner
- ☐ To enjoy ONE specific thing: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

WHAT MY PARTNER (IF ANY) NEEDS TO KNOW

OUR HAND SIGNAL ACROSS THE TABLE (PICK ONE)

- ☐ Touch the necklace / collar means "rescue me"
- ☐ Two taps on the table means "I need a minute"
- ☐ Refill the water glass means "let's leave soon"
- ☐ Other: _____

The two things you've written under "will not engage on, no matter what" are now sacred. Even if you are baited. Even if other people are baited. The point of writing them down is that you do not negotiate them in the moment.

The script library

Twenty scripts for the most common comments. Read them out loud once, a few days before. The body learns them. They come out automatically when you need them.

The body comment

"You look so good, did you lose the baby weight?"

"I'm not really thinking about it. How have you been?"

"Oh, you've gained a little, haven't you?"

"I'm not going to do that conversation today. Can you pass the (something on the table)?"

"You should try [thing]."

"Thank you. I'm not looking for advice on this one."

The pregnancy question

"So, when's the next one?"

"That's a private question, but I appreciate that you care about us. How's (their thing) going?"

"You've got one, are you trying for another?"

"That's not really a conversation I'm having at the dinner table. But I'd love to hear what's new with you."

"Don't wait too long."

"I'll keep that in mind."

(Then you turn slightly, with intention, and start a different conversation with the person on the other side of you. The slight turn is the signal.)

The "you look tired" comment

"You look exhausted."

"It's the season. I'm doing okay. How's your week been?"

"You should sleep more."

"That's the dream."

The unsolicited parenting advice

"In my day we put babies on their stomachs and they were fine."

"I know. The advice has changed since. We follow what the pediatrician says now."

"You're going to spoil that baby."

"Responding to a baby's cries doesn't spoil them. It's how they learn the world is safe. We're okay with that."

"He's going to be clingy if you keep doing that."

"I appreciate that you're thinking about us. We've got it."

The "back in my day" comment

"We didn't have all these (gadgets/rules/sleep sacks)."

"Things change. We do it the way our pediatrician recommends. It's fine."

"You're overthinking it."

"Maybe. But it's working for us."

The political comment

"I cannot believe people support ____."

"I'm not going to do politics today. Can we talk about something else?"

If they push:

"I said I'm not going there. Let's let it rest."

If they push again:

(Stand up. Take your plate. Move to a different seat.
Or take a walk outside. Sometimes the move is the sentence.)

The drinking comment

"Have a drink, you deserve it."

"I'm not drinking today."

"Oh come on, just one."

"No, thanks. I'm good."

"Are you pregnant?"

"No, just not drinking today."

(You owe no further explanation. Repeat as needed.)

The "you're so different now" comment

"You're not as fun as you used to be."

"My life is different now. I'm still me. I'm just running on less sleep."

"You should let loose."

"I let loose when I can. Today isn't the day."

The "I haven't seen you in so long" guilt

"You never come visit."

"It's harder with the kid. We're doing what we can. I'm here today."

"You'd visit more if you really wanted to."

"That's not fair, but I hear that you miss us. We miss you too. Let's plan something for after the holidays."

(The pivot to "let's plan something" is sometimes more effective than defending. It moves them from grievance to coordination.)

The "your partner / your kid" comment

"Your husband doesn't help enough, does he."

"That's our conversation, not the table's. But thanks for caring."

"That kid is wild."

"He's three. He's right on schedule."

"You're letting your daughter wear THAT?"

"Yes. She picked it. She's allowed to have opinions."

The “I am not engaging with this” page

Three short sentences to close a topic without making it into a confrontation. Practice them out loud, briefly, before the gathering.

THE THREE CLOSE-OUT LINES

Line 1, polite:

"I'm not going to do that conversation today."

Line 2, slightly firmer:

"I said I'm not going there. Let's let it rest."

Line 3, the firm-and-leave:

"If this keeps coming up, I'm going to step away for a minute. Please let it rest."

Each line, said calmly, in a low voice, with no smiling and no apology. The body language matters more than the words.

Repeat the SAME line. Do not invent new ones. Repetition tells the other person you are not bargaining.

The grounding-card library

Ten cards. Each one is a sixty-second move you can do in the bathroom, the kitchen, or the porch. Print them, fold them, keep them in a pocket.

Card 1, the cold-water-on-wrists trick

Find a bathroom. Run cold water on the insides of your wrists for thirty seconds. The body reads it as “I went into cold water, I should regulate.” The nervous system slows. It works in about 60 seconds.

Card 2, the five-four-three-two-one

In the bathroom, kitchen, or porch:

- 5 things you can see
- 4 things you can touch
- 3 things you can hear
- 2 things you can smell
- 1 thing you can taste

Counts out loud or in your head. The counting works.

Card 3, the box breath

Inhale for 4, hold for 4, exhale for 6, hold for 4. Repeat three times. Two minutes total. Anywhere.

Card 4, the kitchen “task escape”

“I’m going to refill the water pitcher.” “Let me see if I can help in the kitchen.” Excuse yourself for a task. The task is a real one (refilling, washing a dish, getting something from the car). The body movement is the regulation.

Card 5, the baby-feed escape

If the baby is feeding, that is your time. Quiet room. Door closed. “I need to feed the baby” is the universal language for “I am out of the conversation for the next 20 minutes.”

Card 6, the nursing-cover trick

If you nurse, you can sit nursing in the room and be functionally on your own island. The cover IS the wall. The baby IS the reason. No one will press.

Card 7, the “I left my phone in the car” trick

Stand up. “I left my phone in the car, I’ll be right back.” Walk to the car. Sit in the car for two minutes. Come back. Nobody will check.

Card 8, the walk-the-dog (or the dog’s name) trick

If there is a dog at the gathering, you can walk it. If there is not, you can step outside “to get some air, just for a minute.”

Card 9, the partner-check-in

Across the table, the hand signal. The partner steps out with you. Two minutes in another room. “I just needed a check. Thank you.”

Card 10, the secret writing

In the bathroom, on the back of the pre-gathering worksheet, write one line about how it’s going. Not a paragraph. One line. “He brought up the body thing twice already.” The writing is the venting. You don’t have to do anything with it.

The kid-handoff plan

A page about logistics. Print it. Stick it in the diaper bag or your phone.

WHO IS WATCHING THE KID DURING THE MEAL

Primary: _____

Backup: _____

"If the kid needs me, who tells me first":

THE KID'S CURRENT NEEDS THE FAMILY DOESN'T KNOW

- ☐ Allergy / food sensitivity to: _____
- ☐ Don't offer: _____
- ☐ Their cup is: _____
- ☐ Their nap window: from _____ to _____
- ☐ Their "I'm overwhelmed" signal: _____
- ☐ Their "I need to go" signal: _____

THE PEOPLE I'D RATHER NOT LEAVE THE KID ALONE WITH

(this can be empty, or it can have names)

THE EARLY-EXIT TRIGGER

The kid needs to leave when:

- ☐ Two meltdowns in 30 minutes
- ☐ It's after _____ pm
- ☐ I see _____
- ☐ The kid asks me _____ times

Talk to your partner about this BEFORE you arrive. Not at the gathering. In the car on the way.

The departure script

The polite, firm version of “we are leaving now.”

THE OPENING

"Thank you so much for having us. This was lovely."

(Even if it wasn't. The gratitude is a social ritual. You don't owe sincerity in it.)

THE REASON

"We're going to head out. The kid's already past their window."

(Whether the kid is past their window or not. The kid is always past their window. This is a known thing.)

THE CLOSE

"We'll see you (specific next-date OR "later in the season"). Thanks again."

(Specific is good if you mean it. "Later in the season" is fine if you don't.)

THE EXIT

You stand up. You collect the bag. You take the kid. You walk to the door. You do not wait for permission.

If someone tries to extend ("oh, but stay for dessert!"), the line is:

"We'd love to, but we really do need to get going. Thank you."

(Said while still moving toward the door. Movement is the closing sentence.)

The drive-home debrief

Fill in within 24 hours of the gathering. Best done in the car on the way home, with your partner. Or alone, on the couch.

DATE: _____ GATHERING: _____

WHAT LANDED HARDEST

WHO SAID IT

WHAT I SAID

WHAT I WISH I'D SAID

(Note: this is NOT for berating yourself. It is
research for next time.)

WHAT I DID WELL

THE ONE THING I WANT NEXT YEAR TO BE DIFFERENT

ONE THING TO TELL MY PARTNER (IF ANY)

ONE THING TO TELL MYSELF

The day-after page

For the day after, when the comments are still echoing.

Today is the day after. The comments are still in your ears. The “should-haves” are looping.

Here is what to remember.

One. You showed up. You sat at the table. You did the hard thing.

Two. The comments are not the truth about you. They are the truth about whoever said them.

Three. The person you were yesterday was tired and outnumbered and surrounded by old patterns. The person you are today does not have to keep relitigating them.

Four. You are not required to attend every gathering you are invited to. Next year, you may say no to some of them. That is allowed.

Five. The drive-home debrief is for learning, not for trial. You did the best you could. The best you could was enough.

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A small note on the “boundaries” word

A page to read once, when the gathering is far away.

“Boundaries” is now an internet word, and it has been stretched into meaning a lot of things, some of which are not actually boundaries.

A real boundary is:

- A statement about what YOU will do.
- “If you keep bringing up my weight, I will leave the room.”
- “I will not discuss our family-planning at the dinner table.”
- “If you offer my kid honey, I will move my kid to the other side of the room.”

A real boundary is NOT:

- A demand about what someone else will do.
- “You can’t bring up my weight.” (You can, in fact. I will leave.)
- “Don’t talk politics in front of me.” (They might. I have a choice about what I do.)
- “Be a different person.” (They won’t be. I get to choose how I respond.)

The reason the distinction matters at holiday gatherings: a “boundary” framed as a demand sets up a confrontation you may not have the energy for. A boundary framed as your own next action protects you without requiring the other person to change.

You will not change your mother-in-law at this dinner. You can change what you do when she starts on the body comment.

What this pack is, and is not

IS

- A practical companion for difficult gatherings.
- A script library and a grounding library.
- A worksheet for thinking ahead and a debrief for thinking after.

IS NOT

- A relationship-repair tool. If your family system is genuinely abusive or harmful, please get a real therapist.
- A reason to stay if you really shouldn't. You are allowed to skip the gathering. You are allowed to leave early.
- A guarantee. Some gatherings will be hard even with the best preparation. The pack will not have failed. You will have survived.

Numbers to keep

THERAPIST (if you have one)

Name: _____ Number: _____

A SAFE PERSON TO TEXT FROM THE BATHROOM

ANOTHER SAFE PERSON

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (24/7, free, confidential)

US SUICIDE & CRISIS LIFELINE

988 (call or text, 24/7)



From Soothemade Notes, a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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